

7.1 Newsgroups

7.1.1 Introduction

Newgroups (NG), Usenet and BBS are one of the oldest services available on the Internet. They are similar to the forums that are widespread in the Web at present, in that these are places where people come to discuss, mostly through text messages.

The core of Usenet is a network of newsgroup servers. A newsgroup server operates on the NNTP (Network News Transfer Protocol), similar to a Web server running on HTTP. Each server hosts various newsgroups, and the content in all the newsgroup servers is synchronised on a regular basis. A user starts off a discussion by sending a message to the newsgroup address on any NNTP server. Other users connected to the same NNTP address, and tracking the newsgroup can read that message. After the NNTP server syncs with other NNTP servers the message becomes visible to all NNTP users (this process is sometimes also called message propagation). Similarly, replies to the message are also sent by users to the NNTP server they are connected to, which then syncs the data with the rest of the servers. Usually Internet Service Providers host NNTP servers for their subscribers, though such a service doesn't seem to be offered by any of those based in India.

In the original scheme of things there were eight top level categories of newsgroups, namely soc, comp, sci, rec, talk, humanities, news and misc. Each of the main categories caters to specialised topics: "soc" for discussion related to society, politics etc; "comp" for discussions on computers and related technology; "sci" for scientific discussions; "talk" for discussion on general topics; "news" to discuss latest events; "misc" for uncategorised topics; and "rec" to discuss hobbies or other recreational activities. The "alt" category was added later on, and with fewer restrictions on creating new NGs in this category, it now has the most NGs. Starting a new NG in the "alt" category is more easier than starting one under any of the rest. (But it is still more difficult than starting your own Web forum). Since there is no central authority ensuring a strict classification for NGs, it is common to find NGs under top level category names